

Is AI really an unprecedented environmental villain, or just a convenient scapegoat?

Posted by u/WanderWut • • 0 points • 83 comments

Even when the usual arguments against AI are met with solid reasoning (and someone somehow manages to avoid getting downvoted into oblivion for introducing nuance), just when it seems like the conversation might actually shift, someone plays the “environmental impact” card and that’s it. Game over. That argument shuts everything down on Reddit. It’s treated as the ultimate trump card, unbeatable and final.

But here’s what I keep wondering; is AI really that uniquely destructive? Is its environmental impact truly so unprecedented that it stands apart from everything else we use or consume? Because if you go by the tone of most online discourse, you’d think so. People talk like AI is a singular, apocalyptic energy hog, while conveniently ignoring the massive energy footprints of things like social media, streaming, gaming, or even just endlessly doomscrolling through feeds.

It’s like AI has become the scapegoat for all tech related environmental guilt, while everything else gets a free pass or is somehow seen as a net positive. I’m not saying AI has zero impact, but the way the conversation is framed makes it seem like only AI is the problem, and that feels not just misleading, but bizarrely one-sided.

Comments

u/secretaliasname • 1 points • 2025-07-25 21:09 UTC

It seems some of these data centers a 100s of MW or gigawatt scale loads that local grids cannot support so data centers have onsite natural gas generators onsite to be able to deploy fast. The is 100% non green energy. I’m willing to bet many of these are brayton cycle maybe even open loop brayton cycle which is the least fuel effecient (but cheapest capex and likely lowest lead time) generator option.

u/WanderWut • 1 points • 2025-07-25 21:12 UTC

Oh absolutely from what I looked into this is absolutely the case. But is this unique to AI data centers? How are many of the massive data centers that power things like social media done in comparison? I’m wondering if AI is uniquely unprecedented in this regard because that’s how the vast majority of discourse surrounding AI is presented as.

u/GarudaKK • 2 points • 2025-07-25 15:58 UTC

What you're not considering when you respond by comparison to all other usages, is the scale, frequency and benefit of the other usages. Not just 1 single isolated time, but the aggregate. You are not endlessly running your Nvidia card at max power. Most people don't even game. Your clothes need washing, your food needs heating. Offices running energy relying on cloud-based servers are providing general services that are magnitudes more useful and profitable than emergent "AI".

But society at large, tech at large haphazardly adopting usage of these technologies, even having it run passively on phones, browsers and operative systems, is a significant, unnecessary, and to many of us, entirely unjustifiable hike in energy usage.

People "google" on ChatGPT now, instead of Google searching them. A chatGPT request uses 2.9watt-hours, a google query 0.3watt-hours. **That's x9.6 more energy.**

ChatGPT itself will then also query google and other search engines for information on prompts, nowadays.

And even if you still do choose to just Google, it will ALSO generate an LLM query that you never asked for.

OpenAI said at some point they had **9 billion daily prompts.** There are 112 whole countries on this planet that have a smaller energy usage footprint (individually, not combined).

Why? Why are we doing this? For the benefit of who?

Infinite images, frames and sounds of disposable SLOP content are flooding our platforms, and overloading our cloud-storage systems at unprecedented rates. Grok is being queried to ask "is this true?" when it goes haywire and wastes energy quoting Mein Kampf.

That's the scale. That's the unavoidable frequency, and the non-existent benefit. I don't know if it is unprecedented, but as it stands in modernity, it is quickly snowballing into the biggest issue, with the least practical benefits.

u/Clone63 • 1 points • 2025-07-24 19:15 UTC

I'm really on the fence about the utility of AI, but it's a goddam bargain compared to mining Bitcoin.

u/ph30nix01 • 1 points • 2025-07-23 22:21 UTC

It's ALWAYS a scapegoat.

Because they are trying to sustain the wants of parasites.

Because right now we should be 100% on green energy because it's what's needed for the long term viability of civilization.

Also what kind of idiot would put all their eggs in one basket as far as power generation goes? Why invest in a finite resource as your civilizations future?

It's like putting a forced expiration date..

u/Glittering-Heart6762 • 2 points • 2025-07-23 08:52 UTC

It is the most serious threat to all life on earth.

More than nuclear weapons.

More than a 10km asteroid.

Unfortunately it is also potentially the most profitable and most useful technology humans have invented.

So the incentives to downplay its risks are about as high as they can be...